

Mapping Urban and Suburban Space in the Houston MSA

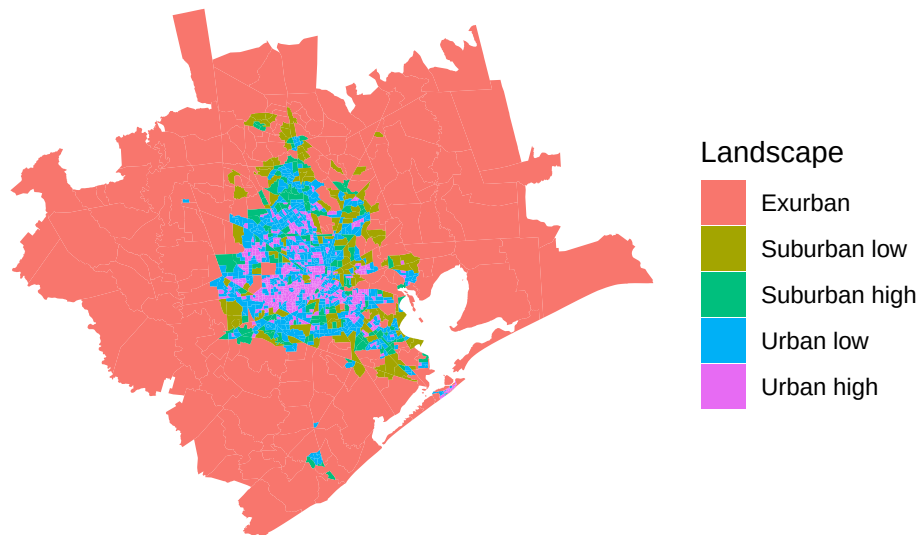
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Introduction

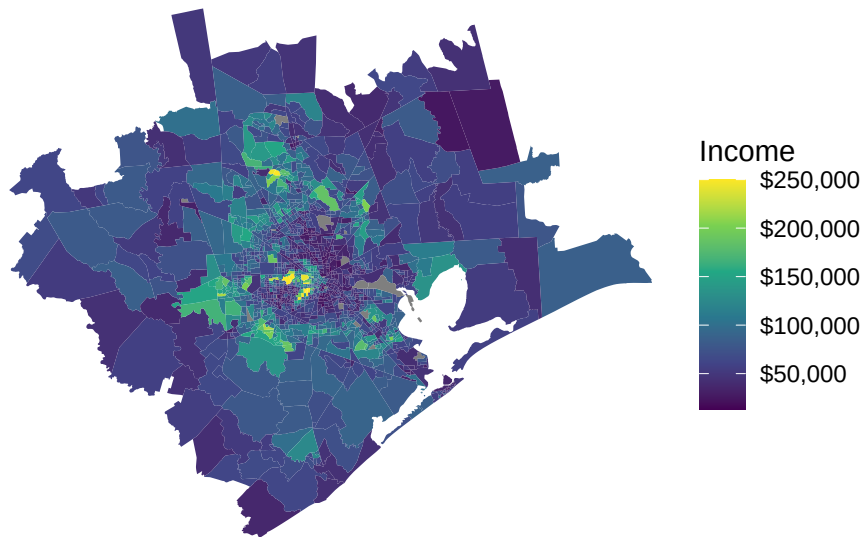
Houston was selected for this project because it is one of the largest and fastest-growing metropolitan areas in the United States and represents a highly decentralized form of urban development. Unlike older monocentric cities that are organized around a single dense downtown core, Houston exhibits extensive suburban expansion and multiple activity centers connected through highways and automobile-oriented infrastructure. This makes Houston an appropriate case for examining the spatial distribution of urban, suburban, and exurban landscapes through Census tract population density classifications.

The landscape map demonstrates that the highest-density urban tracts are concentrated near central Houston and surrounding inner-city neighborhoods. Urban and suburban tracts extend outward along major transportation corridors, while exurban landscapes dominate the outer metropolitan fringe. The overall pattern reflects Houston's large spatial footprint, continued suburban expansion, and relatively low-density metropolitan growth compared to older northeastern cities.

Population-density landscapes in the Houston MSA
2020 Census tracts classified using Hanberry-style density thresholds

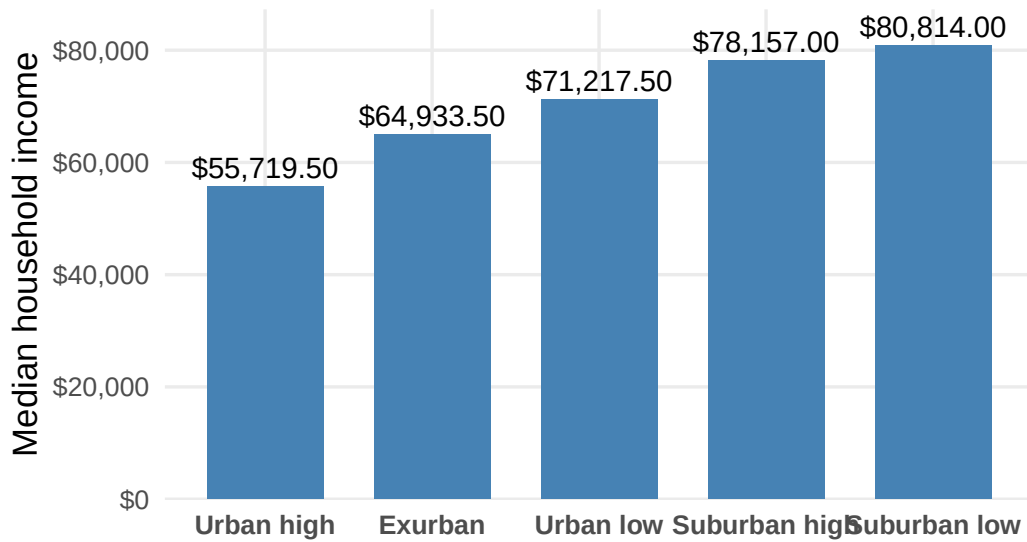


Median household income by Census tract
Houston MSA, 2016–2020 ACS 5-year estimates

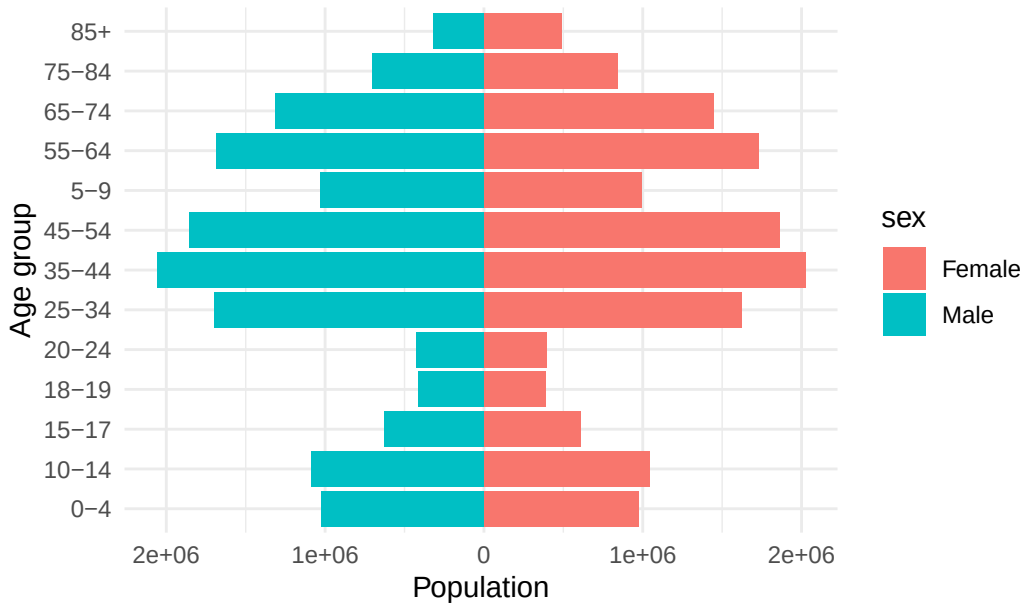


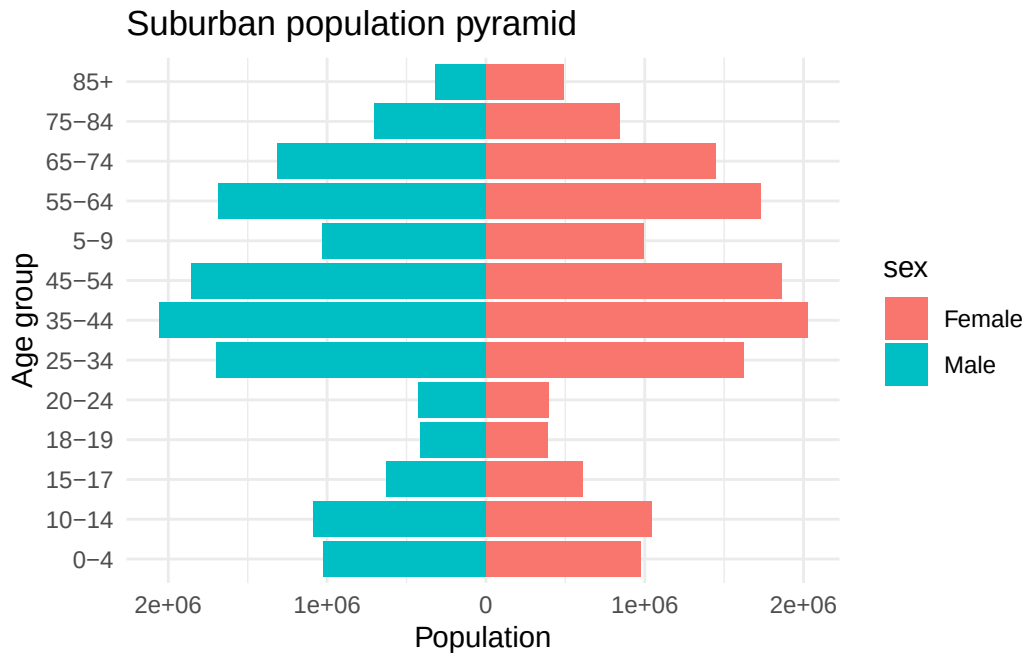
Median Household Income

Houston metropolitan area



Urban population pyramid





Interpretation

The figures reveal clear demographic and socioeconomic differences across Houston’s urban and suburban landscapes. The population density map shows a strong concentration of dense urban tracts near the metropolitan core, while lower-density suburban and exurban areas dominate the outer portions of the region. The median household income chart indicates that suburban landscapes, particularly suburban low-density areas, have the highest household incomes, while urban high-density areas have the lowest median incomes. This pattern suggests that wealthier households are concentrated in lower-density suburban environments, whereas denser urban neighborhoods include larger shares of lower-income populations. The population pyramids also show differences between urban and suburban demographic structures. Both landscapes contain large working-age populations, but suburban areas appear to include relatively larger family-age cohorts and older adults, reflecting Houston’s suburban residential development patterns.